

ITC: Partnering India in its Defining Decade

Excerpts from the Address by

Shri Sanjiv Puri, Chairman & Managing Director, ITC Limited

115th Annual General Meeting, ITC Limited | 23 July 2026

Enduring Value

We meet today at a time of deep significance — for the world, for India, and for enterprises that aspire to create enduring value. The prolonged uncertainty arising from the West Asia crisis has severely impacted the global economy, threatening energy security and trade. Indeed, the multitude of events in the recent past only reinforce the fact that **global volatility is no more sporadic; it is now systemic.** Last year, in my address, I had described this as an era of **TURN** — a world constantly confronted by **Turbulence, Uncertainty** and **Rapid change**, calling for **Novel strategies** to reimagine our tomorrows. Today, that reality stands even more pronounced, as a deeper structural shift reshapes the future of nations, societies and enterprises.

What makes this juncture a perfect storm of exceptional complexity and consequence is the confluence of multiple forces at scale. On the one hand, global progress is challenged by the catastrophic climate emergency, widening inequality and advances in disruptive technologies like AI. On the other hand, decades of hyper-globalisation have given way to fragmented multi-polarisation — creating a world that is still deeply connected, but less trusting; still trading yet marred by weaponisation of supply chains; still global, but increasingly nationalistic. These tectonic shifts are being felt across everyday lives — through volatile commodity prices, inflationary pressures, disruptions in trade and the rising vulnerability of food, energy and supply chains.

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It is said that crisis challenges the status quo like no other and spurs innovation to forge new pathways for growth, competitiveness and resilience. We stand today at such an inflection point with an unparalleled opportunity to make a meaningful difference to all our shared tomorrows.

It gives us immense pride, therefore, that India’s resolute fortitude in accelerating the journey to a competitive, resilient and inclusive nation has earned it widespread trust, respect and admiration.

India’s Ascent: A Beacon of Hope and Progress

Against this backdrop, the Hon’ble Prime Minister’s powerful clarion call for an **Aatmanirbhar** and a **Viksit Bharat** assumes even greater significance. It has inspired multidimensional interventions enabling India to emerge as the fastest-growing major economy in the world. The far-reaching measures announced in successive Budgets have provided strong foundations to unleash growth. India’s ascent is not merely about outpacing other large economies. **It has demonstrated that a nation of continental scale, democratic depth and extraordinary diversity can drive momentum with stability, pursue reform with inclusion, and convert aspiration into resilient growth.**

The India story is indeed an inspiring example of how the Government is creating an all-pervasive Bharat Capability Stack through exemplary foresight and foundational action to reinforce competitiveness for today, resilience for tomorrow and strategic readiness for the decades ahead.

Role of Business: Responsible Competitiveness

It is my deep conviction that businesses, as a crucial organ of society, serve a larger transformational purpose by contributing meaningfully to **national competitiveness, sustainable and inclusive development.**

This philosophy is reflected in your Company’s ethos of **Responsible Competitiveness**, which has guided our thought, strategy and action over the years and inspires our commitment to be **a national value multiplier.** To my mind, businesses make a lasting contribution to the nation when they frame their growth agenda around three imperatives.

First, as engines of national competitiveness, it is mission critical for Indian enterprises to be **future-ready and globally competitive.** This calls for trusted Indian brands that anchor domestic ecosystems and retain value in the country; investments in state-of-the-art national assets that support India’s ambition to become a global hub for manufacturing, services and exports; a deeper focus on cutting-edge innovation and R&D as well as capabilities for AI-led transformation. **The Hon’ble Prime Minister’s vision of Build More, Produce More and Export More raises our collective aspirations to even bolder heights to craft products and services of world-class quality and trust, that earn their rightful place in households and markets across the world.**

Taking this tenet further, the **second imperative** is for businesses to evolve as architects of **national resilience and anti-fragility.** While resilience sharpens the capacity to bounce back amidst adversity, anti-fragility goes beyond, to convert adversity into future opportunities. Strengthening resilience calls for locally anchored value chains, stronger MSME partnerships, diversified and trusted sourcing, import substitution, climate stewardship and robust digital adoption. However, the winners of tomorrow must also thrive amidst adversity, nurture new competencies, accelerate innovation and spur new engines of growth. Resilience is no longer the dividend of efficiency nor is anti-fragility a distant objective, they are the very foundation of our